

Article | 7 August 2026

UNITED STATES

Surprise US job weakness casts serious doubt on Fed rate hikes

The US lost jobs in July and while the unemployment rate fell, it was for bad reasons. Rate hike expectations have declined, but there is a lot happening before the 16 September FOMC meeting



Construction was one of the few bright spots in an otherwise weak US jobs report for July

-23,000 US jobs lost in July

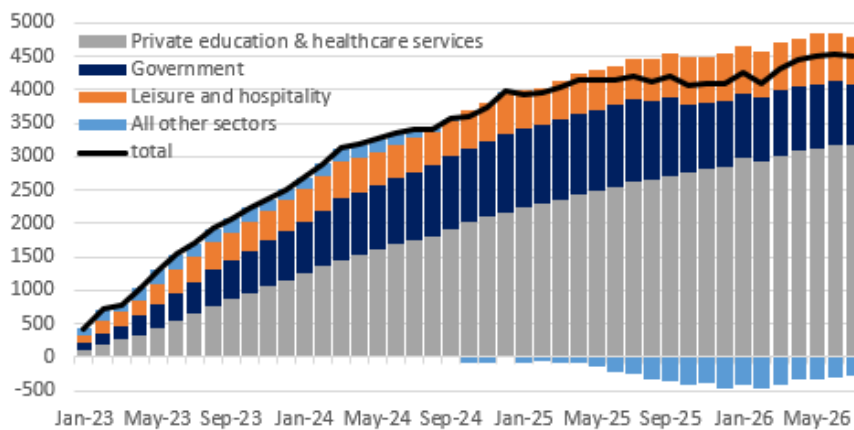
Employment fall highlights corporate caution

The US jobs report for July was surprisingly weak, with payrolls falling 23k while there were 103K of downward revisions to the past two months' data, leaving the 3M average at 20,000. The unemployment rate fell to 4.1% from 4.2%, but not for good reasons. It was primarily because of a further drop in the participation rate – unemployed people leaving the workforce entirely. Average hourly earnings growth slowed to just 3.2% year-on-year from 3.5%.

In terms of payrolls details, the leisure and hospitality sector lost 40k jobs, which may reflect the conclusion of the FIFA World Cup, but we had also seen a 43k drop in June when it was in full swing. The financial sector lost 14k roles while retail lost 19k. The offsetting strength was in

construction (+22k) and, as usual, private education and healthcare services (+25k). The chart below shows the cumulative job creation since December 2022 and indicates that, after a decent March and April, we have reverted to the very weak trend experienced from January 2025-February 2026.

Cumulative increase in US employment since December 2022 (000s)

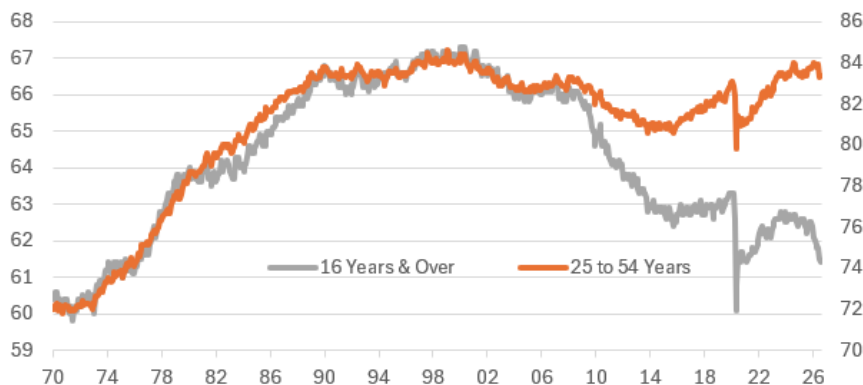


Source: Macrobond, ING

Disengagement drives a fall in participation

Regarding the drop in the unemployment rate and why this isn't the great news it seems, we have to look at the participation rate. It fell to 61.4%, which, outside the pandemic, we must go all the way back to the mid to late 1970s to find a lower reading. A quarter of a million people left the labour force last month. Within that, the number of people classifying themselves as employed fell 87k while the number of people classifying themselves as unemployed fell 178k. Therefore, the fall in the unemployment rate was caused by disengagement rather than for any positive reason. You can see that the participation rate has fallen by more than a full percentage point over the past year. If it had held steady, we would have a US unemployment rate in excess of 5%, and we would not be talking about a possible September rate hike from the Federal Reserve.

Labour force participation rates



Source: Macrobond, ING

What it means for the Fed outlook

Reaction has been significant, with 2Y yields down 8bp and the dollar softening, while Fed funds futures contracts are now only pricing 10bp of a potential 25bp hike on 16 September. Today's outcome supports our call for a prolonged pause from the Federal Reserve, but remember that ahead of the September FOMC meeting we have a further jobs report, two inflation prints and the Federal Reserve's Jackson Hole Symposium.

In terms of jobs, we would tentatively suggest a rebound is possible for August, but the Fed's decision is more likely to come down to what happens on inflation. We expect next week's July CPI expected to show headline prices rising 0.1% month-on-month and core prices rising 0.2%. Cooling housing-related inflation should pull the shelter CPI component lower, while weak wage growth and tariff refunds provide a cash flow boost to US companies, which should all help offset higher costs elsewhere. Assuming we get a deal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, that can feed through into lower gasoline prices and keep the disinflation trend in place through to year-end and beyond.

While nine members of the FOMC suggested in June they think the Fed will have to hike rates, nine said they didn't (plus, presumably, Kevin Warsh). Now of the nine that think they will hike, we strongly suspect only three are voters this year, and they are already voting for a 25bp hike. That would, in theory, mean to deliver a rate hike, we would need to see inflation come in hotter than the nine who didn't think they would need to hike were anticipating. Given we are expecting encouraging news on disinflation, we are consequently expecting the Fed to remain on hold well into 2027.

Author

James Knightley

Chief International Economist, US

james.knightley@ing.com

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Article | 5 August 2026

Stablecoins 101: Uncertain growth but the stakes are high

Stablecoins saw significant growth in 2025, drawing attention from issuers and regulators alike. Still, their long-term prospects remain uncertain. In the first article of our new series, we explore what stablecoins are, what could drive adoption, and why their future matters



Despite a sharp expansion, stablecoins now account for only about 7% of the broader crypto market

Executive summary

Stablecoins have seen significant growth over the past few years, reaching nearly US\$300bn in market capitalisation at the end of 2025. This rapid expansion has come with heightened attention from both regulators and potential issuers. However, the future of the crypto asset remains uncertain as further growth depends on whether it can develop beyond the crypto-landscape and expand into the broader payment world.

In our view, part of the path to becoming a broadly adopted instrument depends on the presence of a regulatory framework and interoperability with existing payment systems. However, estimating the future growth of stablecoins is difficult, as it requires predicting their relative attractiveness compared with alternative payment systems such as central bank digital currencies and tokenised deposits in a rapidly evolving

market.

While the jury is still out on how widely stablecoins could be adopted, it is important to consider a scenario in which uptake becomes significant, as this could have serious implications for financial stability, the banking sector, emerging markets, and monetary policy.

Despite the growing attention, many questions remain about what stablecoins are, how they work, and what role they could ultimately play in the financial system. In this piece, we explain the fundamentals of stablecoins, review recent market and regulatory developments, and explore the factors that could shape their future adoption. While the market is evolving quickly, their long-term prospects remain highly uncertain. Their eventual role in payments and savings will depend not only on regulation but also on whether they can compete with existing and emerging forms of digital money. In future publications, we will examine the implications of broader stablecoin adoption in more detail.

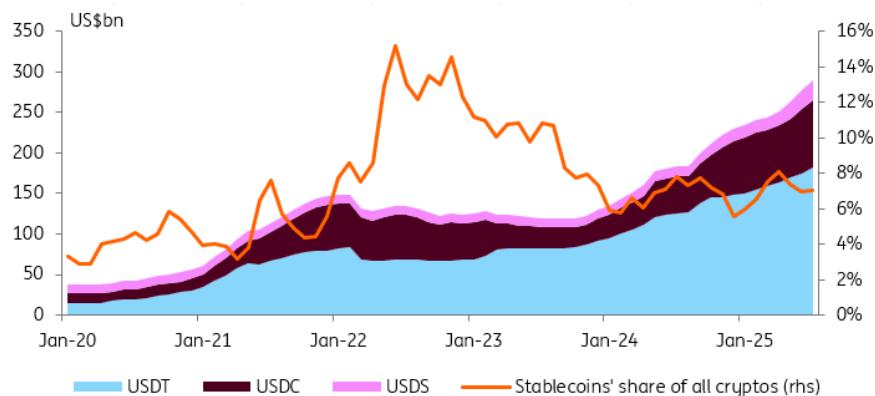
What are stablecoins?

Stablecoins are crypto assets issued by private institutions that promise a stable nominal value in a given currency, commodity or pool of assets. They are not issued or backed by a government or central authority but rather by a private institution and secured by segregated reserves. The crypto asset is issued on a Distributed Ledger Technology (DLT) (i.e. a blockchain) with three existing types of pegging mechanisms:

1. **Fiat-collateralised** stablecoins: backed 1:1 by reserves of cash or liquid assets. These are the most common and utilised type of stablecoin, currently representing over 90% of all stablecoins. We will focus on these in this piece.
2. **Crypto-collateralised** stablecoins: backed by over-collateralised crypto assets. The issuance of these stablecoins tends to be restricted by regulations such as the EU's Markets in Crypto-Assets Regulation (MiCAR).
3. **Algorithmic** stablecoins: not backed by real assets, but the peg to the chosen currency is maintained by a dynamic adjustment of the token's supply using algorithms or "smart contracts". Following the crash of the Terra project in 2022, algorithmic stablecoins now represent only a fraction of all stablecoins.

The total market capitalisation of stablecoins has surpassed US\$300bn globally, 99% of which is USD-pegged tokens. While still dwarfed by bank deposits, the rapid growth of the sector over the past five years (up by \$250bn) has drawn considerable attention. Despite the sharp expansion, though, stablecoins now account for only about 7% of the broader crypto market, a decline from their 2022 peak, as the market capitalisation of other cryptocurrencies has grown even faster.

Selected stablecoins' market capitalisation over time & share of all cryptocurrencies

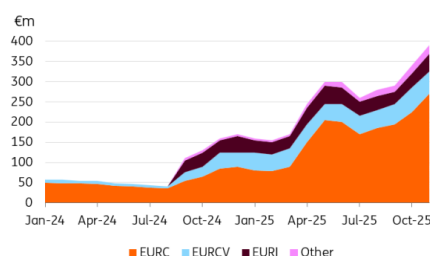


Source: ING Research, IMF / USDT = Tether, USDC = Circle, USDS = Sky Protocol

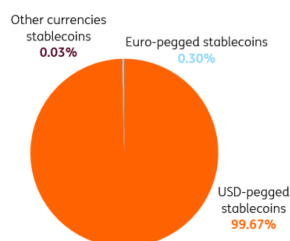
Euro-pegged stablecoins still only represent a fraction of all stablecoins in use, but their market capitalisation grew from €50m in early 2024 to nearly €400m at the end of 2025. Euro stablecoins remain in their infancy, accounting for only about 0.3% of the global stablecoin market despite recent progress.

Euro-pegged stablecoins remain at a nascent stage

Euro-pegged stablecoins' market capitalisation over time



Market capitalisation of stablecoins across currencies



Source: ING Research, ECB / EURC = Euro Circle, EURCV = Coinvertible, EURI = Eurite

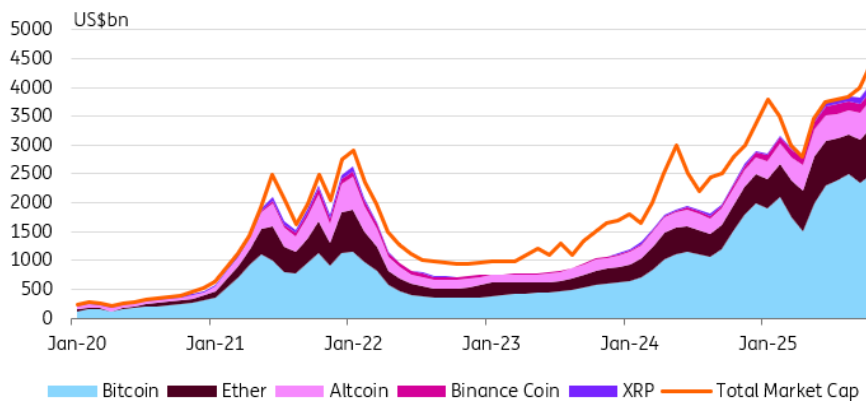
Available data shows that the use of stablecoins remains limited in the larger frame of global payments. Yet the sector's very rapid development over the past years suggests that could change. The new digital currency is forecast to grow exponentially, reaching anywhere between \$900bn and \$4.2tr by 2030. The wide variation in projections underscores just how hard it is to forecast the trajectory of stablecoins over the coming years. Indeed, **stablecoins' growth will depend on several factors: the regulation in place, interoperability with existing payment systems and, importantly, their use cases and relative attractiveness versus other payment systems (new or existing).** The next section delves into other technologies that could influence the growth (or lack thereof) of stablecoins.

How do stablecoins differ from other digital & crypto currencies?

Unbacked cryptocurrencies

Stablecoins are a form of crypto asset, but they differ from other cryptocurrencies by holding segregated reserves designed to maintain a one-to-one value with a chosen reference currency. This is not the case for “real” cryptocurrencies that are also issued and transferred using Distributed Ledger Technology (DLT) but not backed by liquid assets. These unbacked cryptocurrencies are, therefore, much more volatile and used mainly for investment and speculative purposes. Taken together, cryptocurrencies’ market capitalisation reached nearly \$4500bn at the end of 2025, about three times the level in early 2024.

Selected cryptocurrencies market capitalisation over time



Source: ING Research, IMF

Beyond stablecoins and unbacked cryptocurrencies, a new wave of digital currencies is gaining traction among both prospective issuers and regulators.

Tokenised assets

Tokenised assets are digital representations of real-world assets on a distributed ledger infrastructure. A wide range of underlying assets can be tokenised, including securities, bank deposits, and real estate.

Tokenisation is increasingly being explored for bank deposits, where the deposit itself is represented, stored, and issued on a DLT. Each token corresponds to a direct claim on a regulated commercial bank and remains on that bank’s balance sheet. Unlike stablecoins, tokenised deposits do not circulate as bearer instruments but are tied to identified account holders.

The usage of tokenised deposits currently remains limited and mostly experimental. However,

tokenised deposits can modernise payment and settlement infrastructures, as well as intragroup liquidity management. They promise faster settlement (near-instant, in fact), 24/7 transactions, programmability, and lower operational frictions (reducing reliance on multiple intermediaries). Tokenised deposits also offer regulatory advantages, as they remain fully within the existing supervisory framework; the underlying assets stay on commercial banks' balance sheets, preserving the same oversight and prudential standards applied to traditional deposits.

Central Bank Digital Currencies

Central Bank Digital Currencies (CBDCs) are digital forms of money that allow users to pay each other using a direct claim on the central bank. In other words, it aims to reinvent central bank money (cash and coins) in a digital form. CBDCs are often compared and opposed to stablecoins, but the main difference is their direct claim to the central bank. They are issued and maintained by the central authority, often but not systematically using DLTs.

CBDCs can be built for retail or wholesale use (for interbank settlements and large-value transfers). Only a few CBDCs are currently in use in the world (Bahamas, Jamaica, Nigeria and China with a large-scale pilot). But over 100 countries have projects to develop their own digital currency. This includes the EU, which is currently developing its own retail CBDC (the digital euro) and aiming for a 2029 launch. Read more on this in our piece [*The digital euro is making progress, European banks should pay attention.*](#)

In addition to the digital euro, the EU is looking at developing a wholesale DLT settlement strategy. The near-term project 'Pontes' will leverage existing T2 infrastructure and provide immediate central bank money settlement. It's expected to be launched in 3Q 2026. The European Central Bank also plans a full DLT-based wholesale CBDC ecosystem under the 'Appia' initiative, with a blueprint expected in 2028.

To summarise the four digital currencies discussed, the table below highlights the key differences across their main attributes.

Currencies comparison table

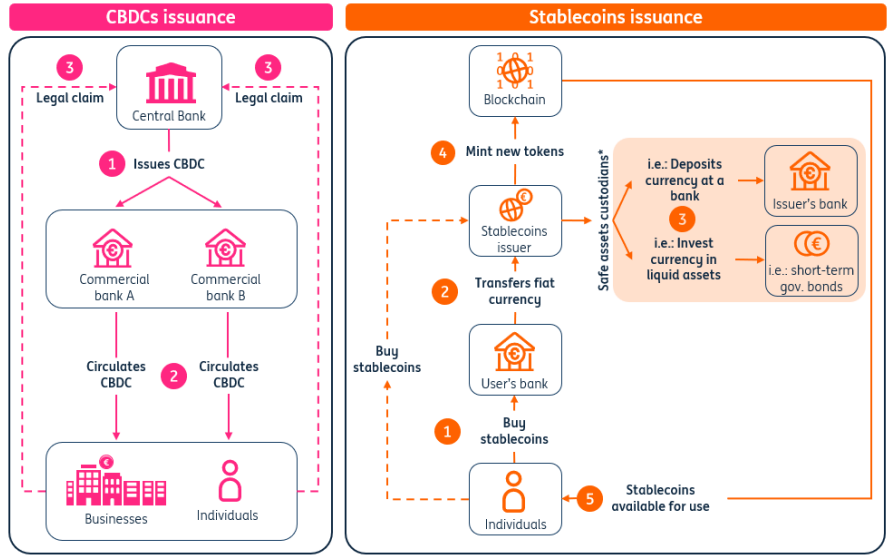
	Stablecoins	CBDCs	'Real' cryptos	Tokenised deposits	Bank deposits	Cash
Digital	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗
Public	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗	✓
Blockchain use	✓	~	✓	✓	✗	✗
Programmable	✓	~	✓	✓	~	✗
Use without intermediaries	✓	~	✓	✗	✗	✓
Large price volatility	Limited by pegging mechanism	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗
Means of payment role	✓	✓	Not in the wider economy	✓	✓	✓
Unit of account role (used for invoicing)	✓	✓	Not in the wider economy	✓	✓	✓
Store of value role	Potential, especially if remuneration allowed	Not if implementation of holding limits	✗	Linked to real-world bank deposits	✓	✓
Regulation	Fragmented	National	Fragmented	✓	✓	✓

~ Possible ✗ No ✓ Yes

Source: ING Research

Both stablecoins and CBDCs aim to create a more digital and efficient means of payment, yet they are often portrayed as competing alternatives. Despite this, the two forms of digital money differ significantly. Their key differences can be illustrated through their issuance models, shown in the flowchart below.

CBDCs versus stablecoins issuance flow



Source: ING Research *examples of safe asset custodians, can vary depending on the regulation in place

The approach to stablecoins and CBDCs varies across the globe, with notable differences between the US and Europe. The transatlantic divide became increasingly apparent in the summer of 2025, when the US moved to support dollar-backed stablecoins while prohibiting the issuance of a CBDC. Europe has taken a different approach, arguing that a CBDC, the digital

euro, would enhance regulatory oversight through issuance and supervision by the European Central Bank.

Given the starkly different political approaches across jurisdictions, stablecoins are likely to evolve as primarily domestic or regional instruments, a dynamic that could shape and, potentially, constrain their overall growth potential.

For stablecoins to become systemically important, their use needs to extend beyond the crypto ecosystem into the broader, global, payments world. However, political positions are already signalling resistance to a global (dollar-pegged) stablecoin, with policymakers instead encouraging the development of multiple domestic stablecoins denominated in local currencies.

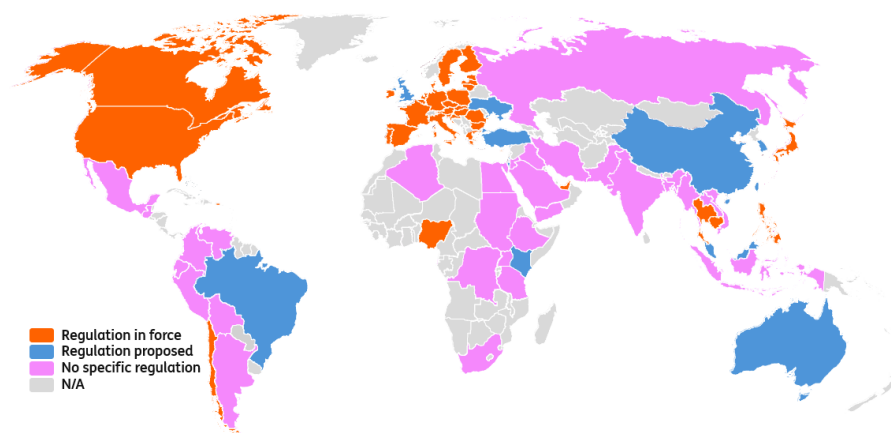
The absence of regulatory harmonisation reinforces this trend. Stablecoin issuers must adapt to each jurisdiction's rules, limiting cross-border scalability and undermining the emergence of a single dominant global stablecoin. The next section outlines the regulatory divergences across the US, EU, and UK.

Large regulatory differences and crucial remuneration uncertainty

Currently, 12 countries have stablecoin regulations in force, and another 10 have proposed texts that are not yet approved. The strongest stance against the issuance of stablecoins comes from China, where they're banned. This partly stems from the government's push for its CBDC; stablecoins are therefore viewed as direct competition.

The main laws are in place in the trading hubs, while other markets still lack specific stablecoin and crypto asset regulations. Despite recent developments at the national or regional level, there's an absence of international harmonisation and coordination on the topic.

Distribution of current stablecoin regulations worldwide



Source: ING Research, Visual capitalist

Because of the lack of international harmonisation on stablecoin oversight, existing regulatory frameworks diverge in several ways. The most important difference concerns the management of the safe assets. Indeed, issuers face various types and levels of restrictions for the segregated reserves. This could influence stablecoins' potential impact on the financial system.

Under US regulation (GENIUS Act), issuers must hold at least \$1 of permitted reserves for every \$1 of stablecoins issued. Permitted reserves include (but are not exclusively) cash, deposits held at commercial banks, short-dated treasury bills and other similar government-issued assets approved by regulators. The absence of specific limits or thresholds on each of these options gives USD-stablecoin issuers a relatively large degree of freedom to allocate their reserves.

This isn't replicated in the European legislation. MiCAR sets stricter requirements for E-Money institute issuers. These institutions (if systemic) are required to hold at least 60% of the safe assets as commercial banks' deposits (30% if non-systemic issuers). They're allowed to hold 40% of their reserves in liquid government bonds (70% if non-systemic issuers).

While the UK is still drafting its final stablecoin regulatory framework, the latest proposal includes restrictions on reserve investments. For systemic issuers, the Bank of England proposes prohibiting the use of commercial bank deposits and requiring that at least 30% of backing assets be held as non-remunerated central bank deposits. The remaining 70% could be invested in short-term government debt. The central bank argues that allowing commercial bank deposits as backing could introduce financial, operational, and contagion risks that could amplify a stress across the sector. Additionally, the UK is the first country to propose a temporary issuance guardrail for systemic issuers, limiting the amount of stablecoins issued to £40bn per issuer for an unspecified temporary period.

While myriad other divergences exist, we also note one convergence between the US, EU and UK regulatory frameworks: the ban on remuneration distribution. All three regimes prohibit stablecoin issuers from paying interest to holders. In the US, where broader crypto market legislation is still under negotiation, this restriction is heavily debated and could ultimately be revised.

Interest payments by stablecoin issuers remain prohibited in most jurisdictions. This restriction is central to the regulatory architecture, as it directly shapes stablecoins' appeal as a store of value and influences both adoption dynamics and its potential footprint in the broader financial system.

The table below summarises the main differences between the three regulatory frameworks. Read more on the various regulatory frameworks in the footnotes.

Summary of the US, EU and UK stablecoins regulatory frameworks

		US ¹ Genius Act	EU MiCAR		UK ² Regulation	
			E-money institute	Credit institution	Non-systemic issuers	Systemic issuers
1.	Access to central bank, lender of last resort	Case-by-case Fed decision	Forbidden	No restrictions		Bank of England considering backstop facility
	Central Bank deposit	Case-by-case Fed decision	Forbidden	Allowed	Allowed	Required i) ≥30% of assets; ii) upremunerated
2.	Asset investment policy					
	Commercial bank deposit	Allowed upper limit to be specified	Required ≥60% of assets (≥30% if non-systemic)	Allowed	Allowed	Forbidden
	Government bonds	Allowed ≤3m maturity	Allowed <40% of assets (<70% if non-systemic)	Allowed	Allowed	Allowed <70% of assets
3.	Stablecoins remuneration	Forbidden for issuer only	Forbidden for issuer and crypto-asset service providers (CASP)	Forbidden for issuer and CASP	Forbidden for issuer	Forbidden for issuer
4.	Issuance guardrail	None	None	None	N/A	Temporary £40bn

Source: ING Research, Fed, European Commission, BoE

1 US has three license levels: for a) bank and b) non-banks at federal level, and c) one at state level for smaller institutions. 2 Proposed UK-regime based on June 2026 proposal in Bank of England consultation

...driving the key uncertainty on stablecoins' uptake

Stablecoins' rapid growth over the past few years, in association with the lack of regulation, has raised concern for central banks across the world. Depending on future growth and use cases, stablecoins could have a significant impact on financial stability. For this to materialise, stablecoin use and adoption would have to go beyond the niche crypto-ecosystem and extend to the payment landscape.

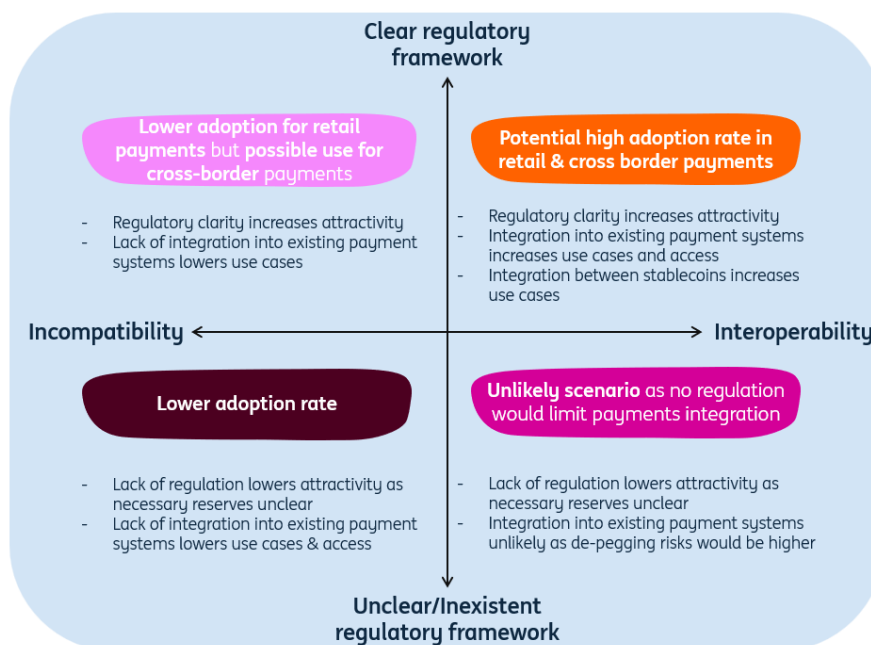
While stablecoins have grown significantly over the years, they are not currently "broadly

adopted". Currently, there's no set threshold determining what would constitute this broad adoption. Furthermore, the development of the crypto asset over the next few years remains unclear. In our view, the adoption uptake would depend on its use for two things:

- Payments
- As a store of value

Starting with the use of stablecoins in payments, there are three main variables. The first two factors are the presence of a regulatory framework and the degree of interoperability between stablecoins and existing payment systems. Mapping these variables produces a quadrant that illustrates four potential development paths for stablecoins.

Potential development of stablecoins in retail payments



Source: ING Research

A scenario with both a clear regulatory framework and full integration of stablecoins into existing payment systems would provide fertile ground for meaningful adoption in payments. However, the extent of such uptake depends on the third variable: the attractiveness of other payment systems (new and existing ones).

The existence and development of alternatives such as tokenised deposits and central bank digital currencies might limit the relative attractiveness of stablecoins. Even though payment systems in Europe remain relatively cheap and fast, that experience is far from universal internationally. For regions where payments are costly and slow, introducing new technologies such as tokenisation into existing systems could allow them to rapidly close the gap with the

advantages stablecoins offer, and potentially emerge as direct competitors to the crypto asset.

There is also a potential political push toward adopting central bank digital currencies, a dynamic relevant not only for jurisdictions with high payment costs but for the EU as well. The digital euro has become a central topic in the 'strategic payment autonomy' discussion and could directly compete with stablecoins for day-to-day payment use.

When it comes to the use of stablecoins as a store of value, a significant uptake would depend on two points:

- Whether direct remuneration by stablecoin issuers is allowed. The current ban on direct remuneration in major jurisdictions does little to support the use of stablecoins as deposit-like instruments, except in countries where real interest rates are negative. However, we can't exclude regulatory changes in coming years, especially as the topic is currently under discussion in the US with the upcoming Clarity Act. Read more on this in our regulatory footnotes below.
- The interest rate level paid on alternative deposit accounts (such as traditional bank deposits), as stablecoins could become more of a competitor to traditional deposit accounts in an environment where interest rates are zero or close to zero (which has been the case in the EU in recent years and is still the case in the US).

Only if, and with the right combination of these factors, could we foresee the adoption of stablecoins growing significantly to become broadly adopted. Yet, at present, it remains difficult to estimate the direction the crypto asset will follow in the years ahead.

Potential implications of stablecoins

Although stablecoins are not yet widely adopted and their future trajectory remains hard to pin down, our forthcoming articles will explore a scenario in which they scale enough to become a meaningful payment system. We see this as a necessary exercise: broad stablecoin adoption could carry significant and far-reaching implications for the financial system – spanning the banking sector, emerging market stability, safe asset demand, monetary policy transmission, and even geopolitical and cyber-risk dynamics.

Indeed, research has found that upon broad adoption, stablecoins could drive significant changes in banks' funding. Depending on the required reserves, this could translate into either a net drop in retail deposits or a switch from retail into wholesale deposits (as MiCAR requires stablecoin issuers to hold part of the reserves in EU commercial banks). Overall, it could make banks' funding structure more volatile as wholesale deposits are known to be less steady funding sources than retail ones (which are rarely moved across institutions). Also, wholesale deposits are costlier to hold for banks as the regulation imposes higher capital requirements, reflecting their higher volatility and general risk level.

Stablecoins could also have implications in emerging markets through currency substitution. It could amplify depreciation pressures under stress episodes by lowering friction around moving local currency into USD stablecoins. Countries with weak monetary credibility (i.e. high inflation, low interest rates) make stablecoins an attractive store of value and payment means, even outside stress episodes. The outflow to stablecoins could further undermine monetary policy transmission.

USD stablecoins also have the potential to boost demand for short-term US treasuries as issuers look for safe asset reserves. In principle, quick changes in transaction-driven demand could then amplify volatility in rates under a stress scenario. The proliferation of stablecoins (regardless of the currency) may also shift the composition of the overall monetary base with an asset reallocation from bank deposits into treasury/government bonds. This means potentially weaker monetary policy transmission through both the credit and interest rate channels.

While all these points remain theoretical implications of stablecoins, regulators are increasingly concerned and estimates on those impacts are developing. In future reports, we aim to contribute to the growing body of literature on this subject by diving deeper into each of these potential implications, seriously considering a scenario where stablecoins become a broadly adopted payment system.

Stablecoins are growing but the jury is still out on how big they'll get

Over the last few years, the market capitalisation of stablecoins has grown significantly, attracting the attention of both potential issuers and regulators across the globe. However, when it comes to the development of the crypto asset, it remains difficult to estimate an exact path. In our view, the growth of stablecoins in the coming years could be limited or strong depending on their uptake in both payments and as a store of value. Part of this growth to become a “broadly adopted” instrument depends on the existence of a regulatory framework and the interoperability with existing payment systems. The difficulty in estimating stablecoin growth comes from predicting the relative attractiveness versus alternative payment systems (new or old) as the sector quickly evolves.

It's important to consider a scenario where the use of stablecoins increases significantly, as this could have serious implications for financial stability, the banking sector, and emerging markets, as well as monetary policy. Therefore, in our upcoming series of articles, we will dive into potential impacts in more depth, starting with the implications of “broadly adopted” stablecoins for financial institutions.

Regulatory footnotes

The United States' GENIUS Act

Adopted in July 2025, the Guiding and Establishing National Innovation for US Stablecoins Act (GENIUS Act) establishes a regime to regulate US payment stablecoins. Despite the enforcement starting in January 2027, the mere adoption of the GENIUS Act had an immediate effect on USD-denominated stablecoins, with net stablecoin creation growing from about \$10bn in 2Q25 (before the regulation) to over \$45bn in 3Q25, a 324% increase in just a couple of months.

The regulation permits stablecoins to be issued by banks, credit unions and certain non-bank entities (although non-bank issuers are limited to financial firms unless the Stablecoin Certification Review Committee (SCRC) unanimously determines that they do not pose a risk to the banking or financial system).

Issuers face tailored capital, liquidity, and risk management rules but are not subject to the regulatory capital standards for “traditional” banks. Banks issuing stablecoins are regulated by the Federal Reserve, while non-banks fall under the Office of the Comptroller of the Currency (OCC) oversight.

Aside from permitted issuers, the GENIUS Act also clarifies stablecoin requirements. **Issuers must hold at least \$1 of permitted reserves for every \$1 of stablecoins issued.**

Permitted reserves include (but are not limited to) USD cash, deposits held at commercial banks, short-dated treasury bills and other similar government-issued assets approved by regulators.

Additionally, issuers of the digital currency must comply with several transparency and reporting requirements, including regular reporting on the reserve composition, and must run audits by public accounting firms. They are required to disclose the redemption procedures and comply with the US Bank Secrecy Act as well as tailored Anti-Money Laundering and Counter-Terrorism Financing (AML/CTF) rules.

The GENIUS Act also currently prohibits issuers from paying interest to stablecoin holders. However, the topic is open to discussion in the US as the proposed CLARITY Act (which aims to clarify the broader crypto asset regulatory landscape) could include the possibility for stablecoin issuers to distribute customer rewards.

The EU's Markets in Crypto-Assets Regulation (MiCAR)

MiCAR was adopted in 2023 and covers a wide range of crypto assets. The stablecoin rules gradually came into force through the end of 2024. They apply to both issuers and entities offering trading, custody, exchange and advisory on crypto assets. **MiCAR classifies crypto assets in three categories:**

- **Asset-Referenced Tokens (ARTs)**: stablecoins backed by a basket of assets such as fiat currencies or commodities
- **E-Money Tokens (EMTs)**: stablecoins pegged to a single fiat currency
- **Other crypto assets**: including decentralised cryptocurrencies and other tokens (not falling into the first two categories)

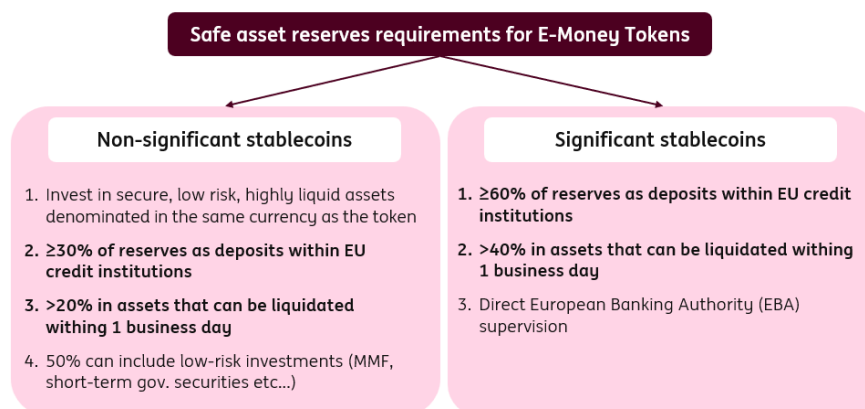
The regulation clarifies which entities are allowed to issue crypto assets in the Union, namely credit institutions and Authorised Electronic Money Institutions (EMIs). In addition, the EU differentiates cryptocurrencies by their size, including specific requirements for the largest assets.

Stablecoins are considered significant when (but not only):

- The **number of holders** is larger than **10m**
- The **value of the token** issued (market capitalisation or size of the reserve of assets) is higher than **€5bn**
- The **average number and transaction value per day** are higher than **2.5m and €0.5bn**, respectively

Under MiCAR, stablecoin issuers are required to have a legal entity established in the EU. The regulation sets out a list of requirements for stablecoins issued in the EU, starting with the prohibition on the distribution of interest on the tokens. It also establishes requirements for stablecoin reserves. For E-Money Tokens (EMTs) specifically, regulatory requirements differ depending on whether the issuer is classified as significant or not. The graph below summarises the safe assets requirements depending on the size of the stablecoin issuer.

MiCAR safe asset requirements per stablecoin issuer type



Source: ING Research, MiCA Regulation

Additionally, all issuers of stablecoins in the EU are subject to transparency and reporting requirements, including the publication of whitepapers on the token's functionality, risk and technology. Issuers must run quarterly stress testing and comply with the Union's AML/CTF

rules.

The UK's upcoming regulation

In June 2026, the Bank of England published a policy statement and draft rules for systemic stablecoin issuers. The BoE's approach to stablecoin regulation varies from existing frameworks as it plans to ban systemic issuers from holding part of their reserves with commercial banks.

The central bank argues that this decision is warranted by the financial, operational, and contagion risks that could arise between stablecoins and the broader financial system during periods of stress. This stance contrasts with the EU stablecoin regulation that requires issuers to hold part of their reserves as commercial bank deposits.

Issuers would therefore be required to hold at least 30% of the reserves in unremunerated BoE deposits and the remaining 70% in short-term UK government debt securities with a residual maturity of up to six months.

The draft rule sets aside the individual holding limit requirement announced previously and instead proposes a temporary issuance guardrail to mitigate risks to credit provision. Each systemic stablecoin issuer will be subject to an initial maximum issuance of £40bn. This limit would be reviewed, loosened and ultimately removed; the BoE doesn't include a timeline for such phasing out. If enforced as such, the UK would be the first country to officially regulate the amount of stablecoins issued, even on a temporary basis.

The proposal plans to require systemic stablecoin issuers to conduct an overall risk assessment to identify, monitor and mitigate risks. Additionally, it sets minimum capital requirements composed of six months of the issuer's relevant operating expenses or the cost of executing its recovery plan. It also requires notifying the central bank when its capital falls below 110% of the minimum requirements.

The Bank of England plans to install a statutory trust mechanism comprising two trusts: one to protect coinholders' interests and the other to cover the costs of returning value to them. Stablecoin issuers will thus be required to segregate the assets used for reserves and appoint third-party custodians to hold these. The proposal also includes a prohibition on the payment of interest and income to coinholders.

Author

Marine Leleux

Sector Strategist, Financials

marine.leleux2@ing.com

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Article | 4 August 2026

GERMANY

Low water levels are new setback for the German economy

Record low water levels in the Rhine could shave 0.3 percentage points off Germany's GDP growth this year



A heatwave in Germany has pushed Rhine water levels to record lows

Some might know that I used to be, and still am, a passionate rower. Rowing on Frankfurt's Main River is not always a pleasure. High water levels and strong currents in winter, combined with commercial river traffic throughout the year, do not make it an ideal place to train. That is, except when water levels are low.

For rowers, low water levels mean calm currents, flat water and very little traffic. Against this backdrop, I have witnessed the effects of climate change during the 12 years I have lived in Frankfurt: fewer periods of high water in winter and longer stretches of flat water in summer. Unfortunately, what has been good for my favourite hobby has become a clear risk for the German economy: low water levels.

Why the Rhine matters for German industry

Yesterday, my colleague Rico Luman [wrote about the impact of low water levels](#) in the Rhine and the consequences for supply chains. For Germany, however, the Rhine is not simply one transport option among many. It is a piece of industrial infrastructure around which much of German industry was physically built.

Roughly 285 million tonnes of freight move along the river annually, making it Europe's most

important logistics corridor after the open seas. It carries about 80% of all goods transported on Germany's inland waterways, while some 600 vessels cross the Dutch-German border every day. The corridor connects Rotterdam directly to three of Germany's largest industrial clusters: Rhine-Ruhr steel, Rhine-Main and the Ludwigshafen chemical complex.

This is no coincidence. The plants were built along the Rhine in the nineteenth century to benefit from barge transport and access to process water, and they have remained there ever since. When the Rhine runs low, the impact extends far beyond supply chains; it strikes at the heart of German industry.

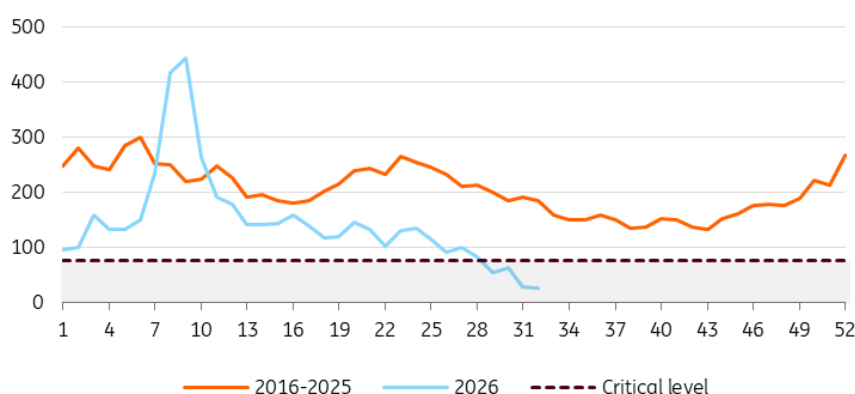
The Rhine's historic importance also means there are no real alternatives. Replacing a single barge can require up to 100 trucks or an entire freight train. And that's before taking into account Germany's well-known infrastructure challenges. Rail and road simply cannot provide a like-for-like substitute for Rhine transport. This is not to say that industry has not reacted to more frequent and longer periods of low water levels. Think of shallow-water barges and higher inventory levels.

Economic impact of low water levels

On Monday, the water level at Kaub fell to 24cm, the lowest level since records began in 1880. The last record low was 25cm in October 2018. This highlights how severe the current situation is. Normally, periods of low water occur between September and November, not in the middle of summer. Yet current forecasts for the next two weeks show little rainfall, suggesting that conditions are likely to worsen.

Water level in Kaub

(average per calendar week in cm)



Source: pegelonline.wsv.de

As the Rhine is home to crucial industries, the economic impact of supply chain constraints, and a potential reduction in production is much larger than the Rhine's c.6% share of total

German freight volume would suggest.

A 2020 Kiel Working Paper found that low water levels in the Rhine, particularly during the 2018 drought, affected the German economy through both transport and production channels. A full month of low water reduced inland shipping volumes by about a quarter, while industrial production fell by roughly 1%. Overall, the 2018 episode is estimated to have shaved around 0.3 percentage points off German GDP growth.

The risk is high that this time around, the economic impact will be larger. The low water levels at the start of August are unprecedented and fully out-of-sample when taking the Kiel paper as a proxy. Obviously, the economic impact now highly depends on the length of the current drought. A week of heavy rain could change the economic picture for the better immediately – even if this currently appears unlikely to happen. Unless the German government finds a reliable rainmaker, we should prepare to see a repetition of 2018 with a negative impact of at least 0.3 percentage points of GDP growth. This comes as a big setback given that the German economy has grown for three quarters in a row and was on track to reach annual GDP growth of some 0.8% this year. A blow to the recovery but not enough to ignite recession fears.

In any case, the negative economic impact will probably make my next outing less enjoyable. Or perhaps not. I may simply find myself humming R.E.M.'s *It's the End of the World as We Know It (And I Feel Fine)*.

Author

Carsten Brzeski

Global Head of Macro

carsten.brzeski@ing.de

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Article | 4 August 2026

TMT

Webinar: The AI race – who will fund and fuel the next wave?

AI is becoming one of the biggest investment, infrastructure and energy stories of our time. Join us to explore how the AI boom is being financed, what investors are watching, and whether power systems can keep pace with soaring demand. [Sign up here](#)



AI is no longer just a technology story. As investment and power needs surge, it has become a capital markets, infrastructure and energy story, too. The race to build AI capabilities is driving unprecedented spending on data centres, compute capacity and power infrastructure. This raises important questions for investors, policymakers and industry leaders.

In this webinar, we will explore how AI expansion is being financed, how investors are assessing the opportunity, and how energy systems can keep pace with growing demand.

You'll learn:

- Why accelerating data centre investment can remain sustainable
- What investors are watching across the largest technology companies
- How AI is reshaping capital markets and financing needs
- How data centres are transforming energy systems and local economies
- How power infrastructure can keep pace — and at what cost

[Click here to sign up](#)

Details

Date: Thursday 13 August

Time: 1400 BST/1500 CEST/0900 ET

The webinar will last 30 minutes, including Q&A.

The event will take place online and the waiting room will open 60 minutes ahead of the scheduled start time.

A joining link will be emailed following registration, and you will receive a reminder email 10 minutes before the scheduled start time.

Author

Jan Frederik Slijkerman

Senior Sector Strategist, TMT

jan.frederik.slijkerman@ing.com

Coco Zhang

ESG Research

coco.zhang@ing.com

Rebecca Byrne

Deputy Global Head of Editorial and Supervisory Analyst

rebecca.byrne@ing.com

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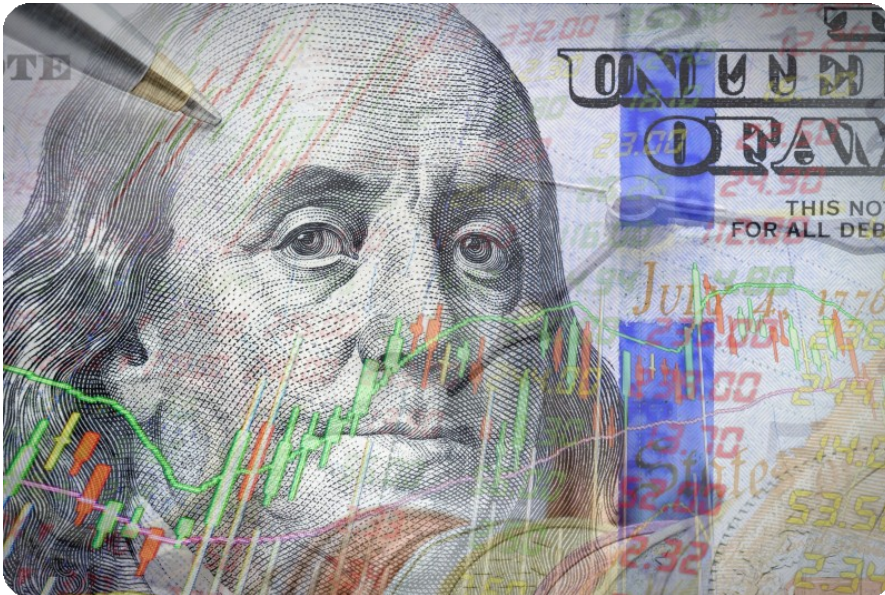
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Article | 11 August 2026

RATES SPARK

Rates Spark: The fiscal number can eclipse CPI

While the transition to higher US yields is linked with the war and higher energy prices, in fact the market discount for inflation is quite relaxed. The July reading is expected to see core at 2.5% YoY. Break-evens are already below this, paving an auspicious path ahead. The fiscal deficit, though, has been morphing in a more bond negative direction



The US CPI number for July will get the headlines, but more focus should be placed on the fiscal deficit deterioration

US CPI inflation is crucial, but the market is already quite relaxed on it

We get updates on the two most important fundamental drivers of US Treasuries on Wednesday, namely US inflation and the fiscal deficit. The former impacts the real return attainable from bonds, while the latter helps determine the supply of bonds. Arguably, nothing else should matter, and if they do, it's only to the extent that they ultimately impact inflation and the supply of bonds.

Recently, the bigger attention has been more on the former than the latter, as upward pressure on energy prices in addition to prior tariff price hikes saw inflation print

uncomfortably high. To the extent that these impulses have maxed out, there is a path ahead for easing in inflation as we progress through the remainder of 2026. That stems from the crucial assumption that the oil price remains contained, through an ultimate reopening of the Strait of Hormuz (in the coming weeks).

The core number anticipated for July at 2.5% year-on-year is absolutely fine, and should act as a rate that headline inflation (now at 3.5%) should trek towards as we progress through 2026. Better still, market break-even inflation rates are running at comfortably below 2.5% (actually in the 2.25% area).

In fact, the market is already discounting a mild inflation landing. It's the higher real rate component that's driven the 10yr Treasury yield higher in recent months, not inflation break-evens.

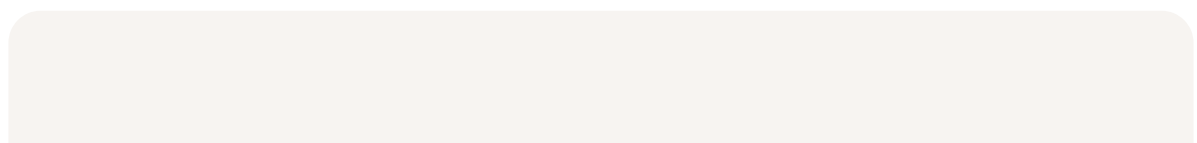
Treasuries have not been worrying much on the deficit, but should start to pay more attention

It's also true that the recent rise in the 10yr Treasury yield has not come from a deterioration in credit perception, in the sense that it's not directly linked with any delta in the deficit. We note that, as the 10yr swap spread has managed to hold broadly steady in the 40bp area since May. That 40bp spread is, in effect, the additional rate that Treasury Secretary Bessent needs to pay over and above the risk-free-rate (SOFR), as compensation for the elevation in the fiscal deficit (6% of GDP area).

Why has it been steady? Well, the good news is the US fiscal numbers have not deteriorated since fiscal year 2024. The deficit for fiscal year 2025 was in fact a tad lower in cash terms. And the running number for 2026 *had* been running steady to slightly below 2025 on account of the extra cash coming in from the tariff revenues.

However, the \$75bn tariff refund paid through May and June flipped the numbers, resulting in the 2026 fiscal deficit running above 2025. Even though there has been a tariff reset / replacement, the 2026 deficit is set to run at some \$200bn above the 2025 deficit. Hence, we're shaping up for a \$2.1tr deficit for fiscal year 2026. The July number will likely confirm the deterioration, coming in at around the \$400bn area compared with \$291bn for the same month in 2025.

If so, we risk seeing a deterioration in the credit story for Treasuries, resulting in some re-widening of the 10yr swap spread. An edge back up towards the 50bp area on a multi-month view is an entirely foreseeable outcome.



Wednesday's events and market view

Geopolitics have been the main driver of rates given an absence of noteworthy data releases at the start of the week. On Wednesday, the US CPI should now provide rates with more direction. While rates have pushed higher of late, the consensus forecast is actually looking for an overall benign inflation reading with an 0.1% month-on-month increase in the headline CPI and a 0.2% in the core CPI. This would help the yearly inflation rates to trend lower to 3.4% and 2.5%, respectively. Other releases for the day are the MBA mortgage application numbers as well as the Federal budget balance for July.

In the primary market space, Germany will reopen 12y and 27y Bunds for a total of €2.5bn. The UK sells £1.5bn in 9ly gilt linkers while the US Treasury will auction US\$42bn in new 10y notes.

Author

Padhraic Garvey, CFA

Regional Head of Research, Americas

padhraic.garvey@ing.com

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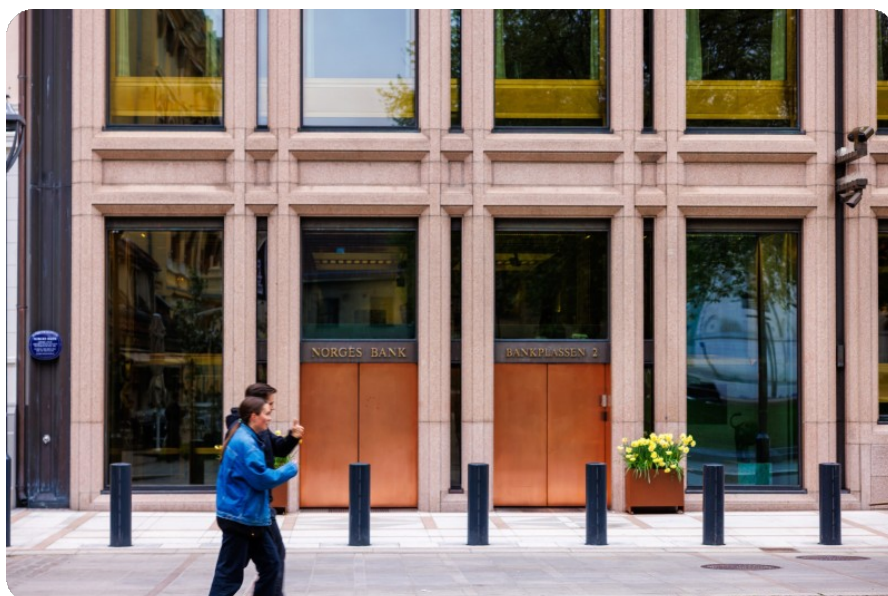
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Article | 11 August 2026

NORWAY

Norges Bank can still hike this year

Cooler inflation means a hold is likely at Norway's central bank meeting on 13 August. Our conviction on further tightening has somewhat weakened, but we still lean in favour of another hike in autumn on the back of an underlying inflation rebound. We remain optimistic on NOK into year-end, even though upside room for front-end rates looks limited



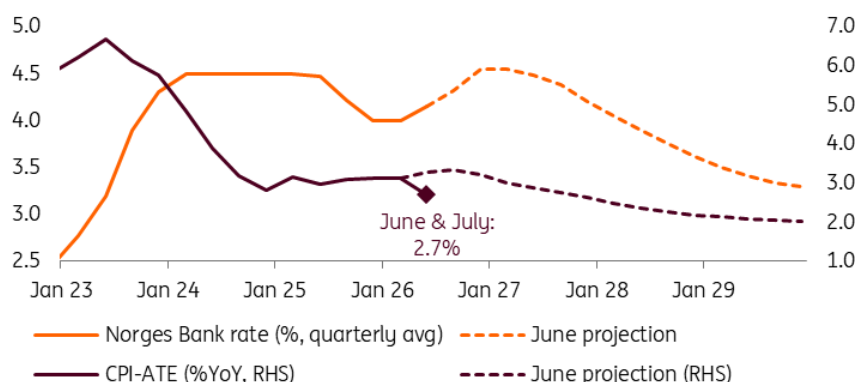
Norges Bank in Oslo

Since Norges Bank's hike to 4.25% in June, we have been expecting one more hike this year, with September as our baseline and some underpriced risk of a surprise move in August. Our baseline was September but saw some underpriced risks of a surprise August move. However, the latest inflation prints have weakened that conviction. We now see a very low risk of a 13 August hike and lower odds of a follow-up move in the autumn, although another hike remains our base case.

Inflation improvement may be temporary

Norges Bank focuses on two inflation gauges: headline CPI and underlying CPI-ATE. Headline inflation fell to 2.7% in June before rebounding to 3.0% in July. CPI-ATE also dropped to 2.7% in June, but then unexpectedly held at 2.7% in July. That is notably softer than Norges Bank's June projections, which envisaged CPI-ATE rising to 3.3% in June and remaining above 3.0% until mid-2027.

Underlying inflation undershot projections in June and July



Source: ING, Norges Bank, Macrobond

The issue is not whether Norges Bank would hike with CPI-ATE at current levels. We struggle to see a case for that. The last time CPI-ATE was below 3.0%, at 2.8% in May 2025, Norges Bank cut rates. Its published projections imply a similar reaction function around mid-2026, when it expected to begin easing.

The more important question is whether underlying inflation rebounds. The June 2025 rate cut proved a policy mistake because Norges Bank placed too much weight on a single inflation print. Inflation quickly moved back above 3.0%, highlighting a degree of month-to-month volatility that we think policymakers now take much more seriously.

Our estimates still point to CPI-ATE moving back above 3.0% this autumn. Recent base effects have weighed on inflation and could begin to reverse as early as August, partly because of the kindergarten price cap. Wage growth also remains elevated, with the 2026 wage settlement at 4.4%.

Hold in August, but another hike remains possible

We also think the bar for another hike is relatively low. Policymakers have consistently framed this tightening cycle as a response to persistent inflation rather than temporary shocks such as the Middle East conflict. Their June guidance amounted to a semi-commitment to further tightening, and we doubt that bias will disappear after only two benign inflation prints, particularly given the recent volatility in the data.

For this August meeting, we expect a rate hold with some acknowledgement of a tentatively improved inflation picture. But we do not expect Norges Bank to remove references to further tightening at coming meetings. Whether that language stays or goes will be the key hawkish-dovish signal for markets.

Our base case remains one final hike this year as inflation pressures re-emerge in the autumn and Norges Bank reinforces its anti-inflation stance. September is still our marginal favourite, although the November and December meetings give policymakers flexibility to wait for more data. We are, however, less convinced than before that further tightening will materialise. If underlying inflation fails to rebound, Norges Bank should gradually drop its tightening bias and shift towards signalling an extended pause.

More upside for NOK than front-end rates

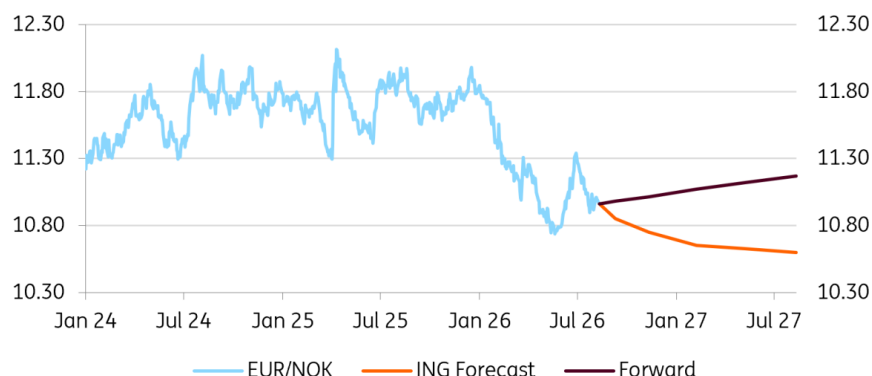
The next few CPI releases will be critical for market pricing. OIS markets price just 3bp for August, rising to 14bp for September and 25bp by December. That suggests investors are not placing excessive weight on the latest inflation prints, but it likely also reflects spillovers from hawkish policy expectations in the US and eurozone.

We see limited upside for NOK front-end rates from current levels. Our conviction on another hike has diminished, and NOK rates could also benefit from dovish repricing in the US if the Fed remains on hold for the rest of the year. Another risk is that Norges Bank softens its hawkish messaging already in August, weakening market expectations for further tightening.

For NOK, we see some downside risks around this August meeting but not beyond the very short term. Another hike (our baseline) would strengthen an already attractive carry profile and reinforce support from improved terms of trade. But even if Norges Bank does not deliver another move, the impact on NOK versus EUR and USD may prove modest if markets are also forced to reprice the Fed and ECB in a more dovish direction. The broader oil and gas story remains supportive. Energy prices holding above pre-Middle East war levels should continue to favour NOK, particularly alongside attractive yields in a carry-friendly environment.

We've recently published a new set of FX views and updates in "[FX Talking: Caught between war and Warsh](#)". We target a gradual descent in EUR/NOK to 10.75 by year-end.

Our latest EUR/NOK forecast



Source: ING, Refinitiv

Author

Francesco Pesole

FX Strategist

francesco.pesole@ing.com

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Article | 11 August 2026

FX

FX Daily: Low volatility prevails

Volatility in FX markets continues to sink as investors seem quite comfortable with the prospect of the Fed holding or tightening the policy rate in September. Expect FX carry trades to remain in demand for the time being, but eyes to stay keenly on the bond market. Here, the issue is whether investors can absorb a lot of new supply from the tech sector



The RBA left rates unchanged at 4.35% today, with Governor Michele Bullock delivering a hawkish message

➔ USD: Realised volatility sinks

Perhaps unsurprisingly, realised FX volatility is sinking in mid-August. The main risk event on the horizon is the Fed's policy meeting on 16 September, where the market prices exactly a 50% chance of a 25bp hike. Whether the Fed hikes or not will be determined by [a few data points](#) ahead of that meeting. However, it looks like investors are not going to be unnerved by that meeting and will, instead, be comfortable picking up carry from high-yielding FX. In G10, the Norwegian krone has delivered the strongest total returns this quarter, while in emerging markets, three Latin American currencies rank among the top four performers.

Should tomorrow's US July CPI release nudge market pricing towards or against a September Fed hike, we doubt it would have much impact on the carry trade.

The one wrinkle on the horizon is the bond market. Longer-dated US Treasury yields are at the

top of recent ranges and the tech industry is planning a lot more issuance. Nvidia announced yesterday it would partner with six investment houses to arrange \$500bn of debt financing for its customers. Buy now, pay later. A sell-off in the bond market probably remains one of the key threats to a benign environment over the coming months.

For today, the US data focus is on July existing home sales and the weekly ADP release. For the latter, the four-week moving average has dropped to +18k from a peak near +38k in April. Any downside surprise here could briefly hit the dollar following Friday's [soft July payrolls release](#).

DXY looks set to continue trading in a 99.50-100.00 range into tomorrow's CPI release.

Chris Turner

➔ **EUR: Gone fishing**

EUR/USD realised volatility continues to sink and one-year is now at 5.8% – matching the low from November 2024. As above, it is hard to see that environment changing anytime soon – or at least until mid-September when central bankers around the world return from their summer breaks.

We published an article yesterday looking at the [dollar hedge ratios](#) of European investors. The risk here is that European investors in the US are once again underhedged and have to quickly raise their dollar hedge ratios should the dollar look vulnerable again. That probably looks more a function of the November midterms than Fed decisions.

It is hard to see EUR/USD trading much outside a 1.1515-1.1560 range today.

Chris Turner

➔ **AUD: RBA holds onto hawkish bias**

The Reserve Bank of Australia left rates unchanged at 4.35% today. Some argue that the added description of the policy as 'somewhat restrictive' means that the RBA is less likely to hike in future. However, Governor Sandra Bullock proved quite hawkish at the press conference, reminding the audience that the RBA sees inflation risks as skewed to the upside and admitting that the RBA did discuss the possibility of a rate hike at today's meeting. This prompted short-dated Australian yields to do a U-turn.

Our team does not see a further RBA rate hike this year, but from an FX perspective, we still see AUD/USD heading up to [0.73 by year-end](#).

Chris Turner

📈 CZK: Inflation details in focus as hike pricing supports koruna

The Czech Republic publishes the final July inflation estimate today, likely confirming the flash reading of 1.7%. The key focus will be the detailed breakdown, especially components watched closely by the Czech National Bank. Core inflation likely stayed at 2.8%, with a risk of 2.9%. The CNB will also look at what drove service price inflation up to 4.7% in July and whether imputed rents continue to show signs of slowing. Last week's CNB meeting, however, suggested the board is comfortable with the current level of monetary tightening, leaving a high bar for another hike.

We had expected the market to price out more tightening after the CNB meeting, but global market pressure has taken over and again pushed CEE pricing toward additional hikes. The Czech market still leads EMEA, with two hikes priced in, reflecting the view that the CNB is most sensitive to renewed energy price pressure after its June hike. We do not expect those hikes to be delivered, but the pricing offers some support for FX. Having been bullish on EUR/CZK before and after the last CNB meeting, we now see the pair peaking around current levels, slightly above 24.250, with scope for some relief below that today.

Frantisek Taborsky

Author

Chris Turner

Global Head of Markets and Regional Head of Research for UK & CEE
chris.turner@ing.com

Frantisek Taborsky

EMEA FX & FI Strategist
frantisek.taborsky@ing.com

Francesco Pesole

FX Strategist
francesco.pesole@ing.com

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Article | 11 August 2026

RATES SPARK

Rates Spark: Tricky relative value amid geopolitics

Oil moves dominate rates direction at the start of the week, although US CPI looms large on Wednesday. In Europe, French budget risks and upcoming elections keep spreads vulnerable, but oil correlations make clean political relative value extraction difficult



In the eurozone, 10y spreads over swaps have once again been driven by changes in oil prices

Tricky relative value extraction amid geopolitics

One of the main drivers of rates market direction remains US economic data and its implications for Fed expectations. Here, the next key release in focus is Wednesday's CPI report. The other driver is geopolitics and the dimming hopes of an imminent reopening of the Strait of Hormuz. This has seen oil prices rise again at the start of the week, dragging rates higher; 10y US Treasury yields reached 4.7% and the German Bund is closing in on 3.2%.

In Europe, a summer drawing to a close soon will also mean a resumption of regular government bond supply and a focus on budget negotiations into autumn. For obvious reasons, the main attention here falls on France. Budget consolidation efforts are hampered by the challenging macro backdrop as well as domestic political uncertainty. All eyes are on the presidential elections early next year, in particular after [Le Pen announced](#) her plans to enter the race.

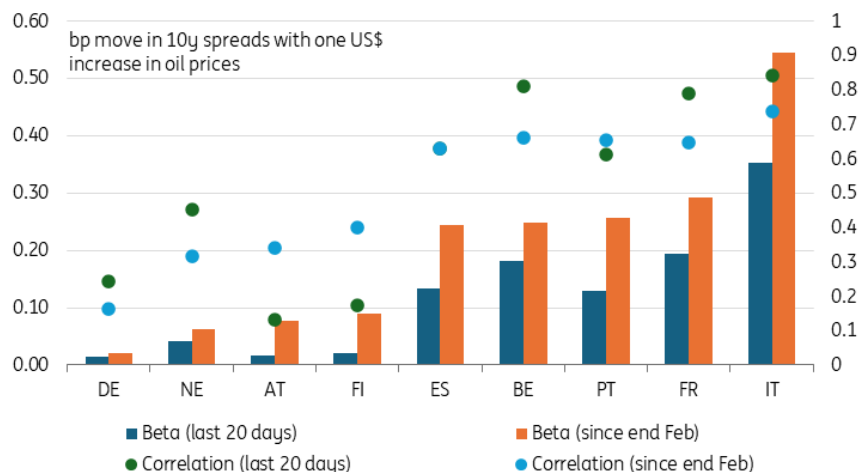
At close to 80bp, the 10y benchmark spread of French government bonds versus German

Bunds is already at the upper end of its range since summer 2024, when the call for snap legislative elections marked the beginning of French political turmoil. Looking ahead, negative headlines coming out of budget negotiations or around the upcoming French elections are still anticipated to bring about bouts of bond spread widening.

However, looking at 10y spreads over swaps for the semi-core and periphery countries, we also see that they have become very much driven by geopolitics again of late, specifically the price of oil. While the associated betas of the individual country spreads – i.e. the size of spread moves on given changes in oil prices have come down somewhat – the 20-day rolling correlations have risen back towards 0.6 to 0.8. For France, that correlation value stands at 0.79, with a value of one indicating perfect correlation.

This already shows the difficulty of isolating political relative value themes from the geopolitical noise. Even intra-country spreads are still highly correlated to oil. If we look at the 10y spreads of France over Italy – which, given the similar spread levels, would be an obvious choice to trade France deficit challenges – a quick regression analysis for data since the start of the year suggests that oil explains more than 80% of the variation. Using Belgium as a peer for France leaves one less exposed to geopolitics, with oil explaining less than 15% of the variation. However, that comes at the cost of higher negative carry given the roughly 20bp spread differential in the 10y area.

Spread correlations with oil remain high, although betas have come down



Source: Refinitiv, ING

Tuesday's events and market view

Geopolitics aside, calendars still hold little for markets to trade on, with all eyes on

Wednesday's US CPI. Tuesday sees the US release of the NFIB small business confidence indicator, existing home sales, and the weekly ADP employment change. The NY Fed also releases its quarterly household debt and credit report.

The government bond supply side sees more action, with Germany auctioning 5y bonds (€6bn) and Finland selling 10y and 17y bonds (€1-1.5bn). The US Treasury later auctions new 3y notes (US\$58bn).

Author

Benjamin Schroeder

Senior Rates Strategist

benjamin.schroeder@ing.com

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Article | 11 August 2026

COMMODITIES DAILY

The Commodities Feed: Oil higher as US-Iran deal hopes fade

Oil prices are trading stronger as optimism over a US-Iran deal fades, leaving the market to reprice ongoing supply disruptions



Energy - Middle distillate tightness concerns grow

By this point, you'd think markets would be largely immune to headlines about a US-Iran deal. The pattern keeps repeating — initial enthusiasm when negotiations appear promising, only for that optimism to dissipate just as quickly. Yet the oil market remains very headline-driven, which leaves prices whipsawing. The latest bout of optimism is quickly fading, with demands for war reparations from Iran, which President Trump rejected. Trump instead insists that Iran pay reparations for the deaths of US soldiers as well as Iranian civilians over the last few decades. Current rhetoric suggests any potential deal is still some way off, meaning risks remain skewed to the upside for oil prices.

Oil continues to move through the Strait of Hormuz even as disruptions persist, underscoring the market's ability to keep flows moving despite periodic turbulence. According to reports, Iraq's state oil marketing company said oil shipments are around 2m b/d in August. If this is the case, a number of vessels would be navigating the strait with transponders turned off, given that observed tanker crossings are minimal. Prior to the war, Iraq was exporting around 3.4m b/d of oil through the Strait of Hormuz.

Middle distillates saw renewed strength yesterday, with the ICE gasoil crack surging above \$70/bbl at one stage, after further Houthi attacks on the 400k b/d Jazan refinery in Saudi

Arabia. The refinery had already suspended operations due to a previous attack. The latest incident will reportedly see the refinery restart operations at the end of August. This will clearly only add to supply concerns for refined product markets, particularly middle distillates. The outlook for gasoil will depend largely on how events in the Middle East and Russia play out. With tight stocks heading into the Northern hemisphere winter, it's clear that gasoil cracks will remain at seasonally elevated levels.

Fading optimism over a potential deal between the US and Iran has also seen European natural gas prices surge higher once again. TTF settled more than 9% higher yesterday, taking it back above EUR60/MWh. Every day that goes by without a resumption of Persian Gulf LNG flows leaves the market more vulnerable as we head closer towards the 2026/27 heating season. The state of storage in Europe is becoming a bigger worry. Gas storage is now below 2021 levels both in terms of percentage full and in absolute terms. The EU's lower storage target of 75% ahead of the winter is looking as though it will be tough to hit. This will leave the market vulnerable to price spikes through the heating season.

Agriculture – Supply tightness lifts sugar to 10-month high

Sugar prices remained near their highest level since October 2025, following their largest weekly gain since 2024 — supported by tightening global supply conditions. Europe's sugar production is expected to decline to a multi-year low, while potential El Niño-related disruptions to cane production in India and Thailand continue to bolster market sentiment. Speculators reduced their net short position by 34,599 lots to 77,814 lots, driven primarily by short covering. Gross short positions declined by 19,413 lots to 274,809 lots.

Favourable weather conditions in the Ivory Coast are helping cocoa farmers prepare plantations ahead of next month's main harvest. Meanwhile, rainfall has returned to Cameroon and Nigeria, improving crop conditions and supporting fresh flowering. This is despite some losses of young flowers and pods. In Ghana, favourable weather has supported crop development throughout the season. Limited sunshine is beginning to raise concerns over the spread of black pod disease.

First estimates from Ukraine's Agriculture Ministry show that grain exports could decline to 38mt—40mt in the 2026/27 marketing season, down about 12% from an earlier projection of 43mt. The revision is largely attributed to persistent Russian attacks on Odesa's port infrastructure and disruptions to Black Sea shipping routes.

Author

Warren Patterson

Head of Commodities Strategy

Warren.Patterson@asia.ing.com

Ewa Manthey

Commodities Strategist

ewa.manthey@ing.com

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Article | 10 August 2026

FX

Low dollar hedge ratios: could lightning strike twice?

Since last year's 'Liberation Day' collapse of the dollar, there has been a lot of focus on dollar hedge ratios. Low levels of dollar hedging heading into that April 2025 tariff announcement were widely seen as contributing to the sharp dollar sell-off. Data suggests those hedge levels are getting very low again



Everyone loves the dollar

US President Trump's decision to launch a military assault on Iran at the end of February triggered widespread dollar buying. This was largely a function of the energy story, where the 'haves' – the US – were rewarded at the expense of the 'have-nots' – Europe and Asia. The dollar received a second fillip in June when it looked like new Fed Chair, Kevin Warsh, was about to restore the Fed's inflation-fighting credibility with a rate hike.

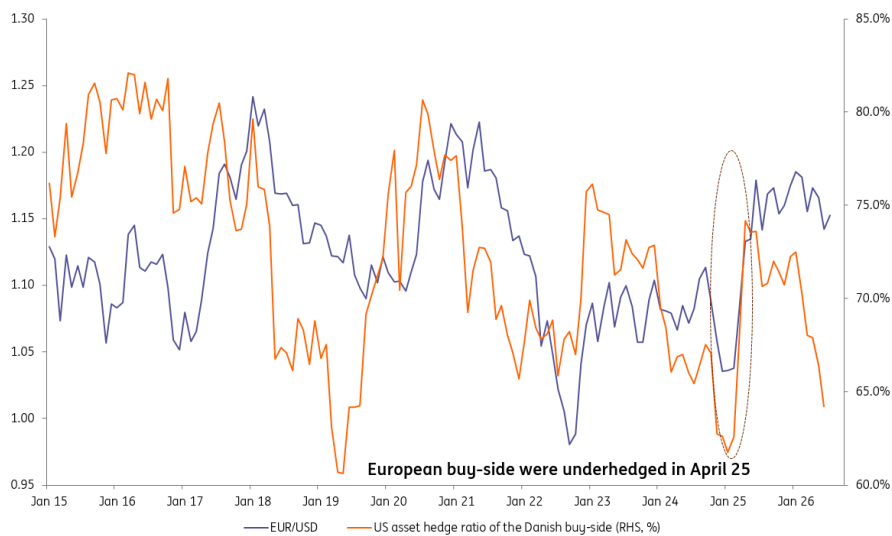
That summer optimism on the dollar looks to have carried through to the buy-side, where some estimates suggest that European FX hedge ratios on US investments have been cut back to their lowest levels since February 2025.

The data we show in the chart below comes from the Danish central bank and marks the FX

hedge ratios from Denmark's insurance and pension fund industry. We appreciate this is just a snapshot of a very broad European buy-side, but the data did capture the events of March/April 2025 pretty well. Back then, the Danish buy-side went into 'Liberation Day' tariffs with hedge ratios on US investments at 63%, only to rush them up to 74% by the end of April.

As of the end of June this year, these hedge ratios have been cut back to 64% – presumably on the conviction view that most roads lead to a firmer dollar.

European buy-side US hedge ratios fall again



Source: Danish Central Bank, Refinitiv

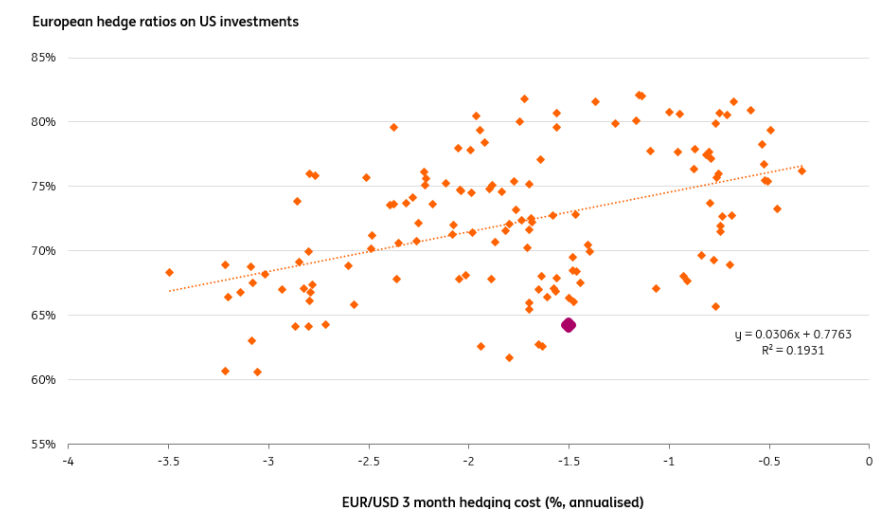
European buyside looks underhedged

But looking at this data, it seems fair to describe the European buy-side as 'underhedged' when it comes to its US investments. While not as statistically significant as it could be, data since 2015 suggests that if hedge ratios were merely a function of hedging costs, European hedge ratios on US investments should be a lot higher. Current (relatively cheap) hedging costs of 1.5% per annum using the three-month EUR/USD forward would be more associated with a 73% hedge ratio rather than the 64% seen in the latest data in June.

This begs the question whether lightning will strike twice and some, presumably US-centric event, will trigger another dramatic European increase in dollar hedge ratios and a sharp dollar sell-off? We have no particular insights into the triggers here, but do note that the prediction market, Polymarket, currently attaches a 30% probability that President Trump declares a national emergency by the end of this year in response to interference in US elections or election processes. The reference here is clearly to the US midterm elections, which take place on 3 November. The FX option market has already marked this as a potentially big day, with volatility priced at 150% of a normal trading day.

None of the above is in our baseline FX forecasts, but low dollar hedge ratios are helpful to our [EUR/USD 1.18 end-year forecast](#) – a forecast largely premised on unchanged Fed policy this year.

US hedge ratios versus EUR/USD hedging costs



Source: Danish Central Bank, ING

Author

Chris Turner

Global Head of Markets and Regional Head of Research for UK & CEE

chris.turner@ing.com

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